
**Unit 1, Option E/F,
Topic E/F6: The
Middle East, 1945-
2001: The State
of Israel and Arab
Nationalism**

The focus of this topic is on the growing conflict in the Middle East arising from Arab and Israeli ambitions in Palestine, the growth of Arab nationalism, and the extent to which it changed as a result of the growth of religious fundamentalism. Since the focus of this unit is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the specification content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the specification content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

The bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, an explanation of the Arab–Israeli conflict (bullet point 3) would draw also on the problems created by the post-war settlement (bullet point 2).

The first bullet point in the specification focuses on the origins of the conflict in Palestine. Students are not required to have detailed knowledge of events before 1945 but they should understand the roots of Arab–Israeli hostility and the reason for the British presence. They should have knowledge of post-war immigration, the British response, the impact of terrorism, the process leading to the creation of the state of Israel in 1948, and of American links with Israel.

The second bullet point is focused on the Arab–Israeli conflict to 1973. Students should have understanding of Arab attitudes in 1948, the reasons for an attack on Israel, Israel’s survival and the growth of hostility thereafter. This can be exemplified by the Suez crisis of 1956, and the reasons for the Six Day War. Students should understand the extent of Israel’s victory and the impact on the Palestinian people. They can refer to the refugee problem, Israeli settlement in the occupied territories, the activities of the PLO and the renewal of war in 1973. They should be aware of the extent of Israeli dominance in the area, the range of territory retained in Israeli hands and its impact on Syria, Jordan and the Lebanon.

The third bullet point focuses on Arab nationalism and its development to 1979. Students should be aware of the desire for Arab unity after the collapse of the Turkish Empire and the impact of the Second World War on Arab attitudes, and can exemplify development thereafter from the overthrow of Farouk in Egypt and the emergence of Nasser, the impact of Suez, and the withdrawal of British influence in Iraq and Jordan. They should understand the aims of Arab nationalists in these states, the desire for secular modernisation and the role of the Soviet Union, and can refer to the reasons for the creation of the United Arab Republic and its failure. Students should also have knowledge of events in Iran, with the Shah’s desire to modernise and his fall in 1979 as a result of fundamentalist reaction. They should also understand the main differences between Shia and Sunni Muslims and the impact of Khomeini’s regime in Iran on relations between them.